(but still explicitly Jewish) society. Ayelet Shaked, the justice minister and a secular Jew, inaugurated a new *shari'a* court in the summer of 2016, a scene that would be unthinkable in, say, republican France.

Still, a shared language and calendar only get you so far. How much do the urban Jewish sophisticates in Tel Aviv have in common with the ideological Jewish settlers living on the hills outside of Nablus, or the ultra-Orthodox Jews in the modern-day *shtetls* of Bnei Brak? Israel feels increasingly like a group of cantons, bound by the most tenuous of threads.

Haviv Rettig Gur, the political analyst for the *Times of Israel*, once offered a third idea for what holds the country together. "Israeli Jews share a profound sense of standing shoulder to shoulder in a pitiless and often bloodthirsty world, a world that has impressed upon them the need to fend for each other, often alone," he wrote in 2015.[1]

This was strong glue in the decades after 1948, when Israel was surrounded by hostile (and much larger) Arab states, and with the memory of the Holocaust still fresh. It weakened after the treaties with Egypt and Jordan. Still, the peace process continued to stitch up Israeli society, albeit into two halves: a "peace camp" which believed that a two-state solution was the only way to safeguard the country's future; and an opposing group which felt otherwise. But there was a sense of shared destiny, that both sides were arguing over a common fate.

By 2016, though, there was no real threat to draw Israelis together in solidarity. The country has peace treaties with two of its four neighbors; a third, Syria, is in ruins; and the fourth, Lebanon, is so weak that Israel routinely uses its airspace to launch strikes in Syria. (Hezbollah poses a serious threat, but hardly an existential one, and it is constrained by both its involvement in Syria and by Israeli deterrence.) Neither the Iranian nuclear program nor the BDS movement currently threatens Israel's survival. And the status quo with the Palestinians, rightly or not, seems sustainable well into the future. Few Israelis give it much thought on a daily basis. So Israeli society cannot be drawn together by the need to stand "shoulder to shoulder" in the face of an existential threat, because one does not exist.

Perhaps there is a fourth option, then: the Israel of 2016 is a society drawn together by nostalgia. This is an odd concept in a state populated mostly by Jews, a people whose history offers little cause for wistfulness. Yet the turmoil of the past few years suggests that a current of nostalgia runs through not only Israel, but societies around the developed world. In